

There was a Miss South India contest scheduled in CTC the day we landed in Chennai. While our editor, IT admin and logistics guy blissfully bought off the passes and indulged in sin, our correspondents worked frantically to sort out last minute issues back at the hotel!

content of the event was developed with these two focus areas in mind. To address the needs of the industry, we created an IT Managers' Track. And to connect the new generation of developers (or those unaware of the advantages of the open source development stack) to the community, we created the Software Developers' Track.

First day, first show!

Steve Lau, senior consultant at HK OSS Centre, did the honours at the lamp lighting ceremony, along with Dr P. Balasubramanian, head of open technology centre, National Informatics Centre (NIC), Dr S. Ramakrishnan, director general, C-DAC, Dr M.R. Rajagopalan, executive director, C-DAC, and Poonam Kapoor, director, EFY Group.

Following this, Dr Ramakrishnan delivered the inaugural address. He focused on the impact of free/libre and open source software all over the world and India's role in spreading it. He said that India had immense manpower in open source, and if we used it fruitfully it could be a tremendous power, worldwide.

"The key thing in spreading open source is to adopt it. Issues like interoperability and LSI compliance in open source are being sorted out. Here the government is very supportive to the idea of FOSS and many governmental projects are being done using it," he conveyed. He also added that there is tremendous opportunity in the field; however, it still requires a lot more community-based initiatives and forums to groom it.

Steve Lau delivered the keynote address. He pointed out that the Asian OSS Centre, which covers many countries—including India, Hong Kong, Pakistan, Japan and Indonesia—was set up on March 27, 2008 to promote FOSS in Asia. Its purpose is to facilitate the information and knowledge exchange

among the participating countries. "Asia has huge opportunities for open source and there is wide scope for learning in the field. Open source will give immense job opportunities to entrepreneurs, and that's why Asian countries should introduce and promote open source in various projects," he elaborated. Dr Balasubramanian also spoke during the inaugural session.

Post the inaugural addresses, the event was split between the two parallel tracks, one for IT managers and decision-makers, and the other one targeting developers.

Software Development Track

This track was aptly titled FOSS-powered Software Development. It witnessed discussions on various topics ranging from software development technologies, FOSS databases, tools for creating top quality software, etc.

The session was kicked off by Dhiraj Sinha, head of technology at Perot Systems' Applications Solutions Group. He stressed on where and why Perot Systems is using open source technologies for its software development requirements. This was followed by a panel discussion that guided the audience on how to migrate from the proprietary to the FOSS stack for development.

During the course of the day, PK. Mishra, principal consultant architect, Novell, said that users have a variety of choices available in FOSS compared to the small footprint of Microsoft. Pointing out Mono, he noted that the platform is a complete FOSS implementation of the .NET framework, which runs on both Linux and Windows, among other systems. He added that the .NET apps that are meant for compilation in Visual Studio can be compiled without any changes directly on Mono, which means you have your favourite .NET applications running on Linux.

Supreet Sethi, who likes to describe himself as a photographer by choice (although a freelance software developer by profession, just so he can afford his passion for photography), took up the topic of FOSS databases. He pointed out that many of the conventional

databases worked almost the same way. A vendor generally recommends a particular database for a specific use. For example, MySQL is recommended for content management, yet if you are in a transaction process company, MySQL is the worst option.

John Smedley, senior architect, Ingres Corporation, elaborated, "If we are looking for a specific product to solve a specific problem, we need to know the problem thoroughly. We need to know the needs to build a prototype according to it."

Ashish K. Mathur, software architect, IBM, stressed on the importance of 'testing' in open source. He also turned the spotlight on the unique spirit of volunteerism that drives innovation in the open source world. "Nobody is doing it [testing software] because they were asked to do so," he said.

The importance of a version control system (VCS) to create top quality software was covered by Bhuvaneshwar A. of CollabNet. Technically, a VCS is a piece of software that tracks differences between every 'Save' you do in your code (called 'commits' in VCS nomenclature) and stores it, so that it can recall the state of the file before any of the 'Save' operations that you performed. This can be a great help in troubleshooting. If a bug was introduced into the code unknowingly and the issue was noticed, say, two years after the viral commit was made, with a VCS you could know when it got into the cycle and track it easily.

IT Managers' Track

Running parallel to the software development track were programmes

While it made our chests heavy with pride witnessing over 50 speakers being eager to take up the podium and speak before the half packed audiences, it was also a pain to cut a few of our speakers short owing to shortage of time. During one such incidence, a speaker got royally pissed, dropped the microphone on the podium and walked off. Sir, we'd like to apologise for the inconvenience.